



Ukraine, Moldova, & Romania

THROUGHOUT MUCH OF THE LAST CENTURY, Ukraine and Moldova formed part of the Soviet Union (USSR), while Romania was ruled for 20 years by the communist dictator Nicolae Ceausescu. In 1989, Ceausescu was overthrown, while Ukraine and Moldova became independent in 1991. Today, the three countries are still struggling to fully transform themselves into modern democracies, although Romania joined the EU in 2007. Outdated technology, dependency on gas and oil from their powerful neighbor Russia, and economic and environmental problems have slowed their progress. It is also a region of ethnic tensions, highlighted in 2014 when Russia annexed Ukraine's Crimean peninsula, where a large part of the population consists of Russians left behind after the USSR break-up.



CITY LIFE
Romania has many cities and towns with a mix of old and new buildings. Sibiu (left) was founded in the 12th century and, at one time, had 19 guilds—each representing a different craft—within its city walls. Much remains from this colorful history, especially in the painted buildings of the old town.

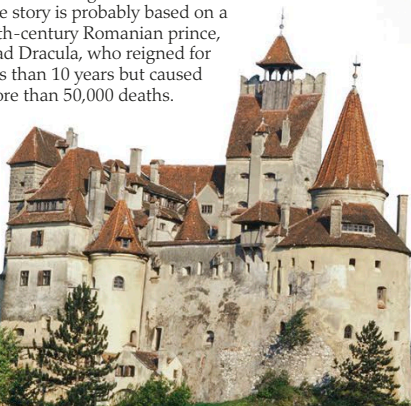
FOLK CUSTOMS

Despite years of communist rule, folk customs thrived in the rural areas of Romania and Ukraine. In Ukraine, singers perform *dumas*, historical epics that tell of slavery under the Turks. One of the traditional instruments is a bandura (left), a stringed instrument that sounds like a harpsichord.



DRACULA'S CASTLE

Situated in Transylvania, Bran Castle is a favorite tourist destination. This is where author Bram Stoker's fictional blood-drinking Count Dracula lived. The story is probably based on a 15th-century Romanian prince, Vlad Dracula, who reigned for less than 10 years but caused more than 50,000 deaths.



The word Transylvania means "land beyond the forests."

EASTER BREAD

In Romania, Easter is celebrated with a meal of roast lamb served with a bread called *cozonac*. This is made by pounding nuts, raisins, and even cocoa, into the dough.

